

New media in relation to narration

An analysis of *Luscinia*, *Luscinia: A Night's Mad Stories*



New media in relation to narration

5th semester

Group 3

Narratives and Interaction

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Abstract

This report investigates usage of media in theatre performances, with focus on the media's influence on narration and stage design. The study uses the performance *Luscinia*, *Luscinia: En nats gale fortællinger*, devised and performed by 5th semester, Art and Technology(AAU, 2023), as a case. The performance is based on an interpretation of H.C. Andersen's fairytale *The Nightingale*, which led to a theatrical adaptation centred around a narration with multiple storylines with media as means. The report begins by identifying elements of postdramatic theatre in relation to the Aristotelian view of drama. It then explores these elements, together with relevant theory of media and narration, such as Saltz and Nussbaum, to enable an understanding of ways of using media to influence other aspects of a performance.

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1. Introduction

This semester's theme is Narratives and Interaction with the focus of puppets, objects and new media. Another important focus was the collaboration processes, both with the internal collaborations and the collaboration with an external partner, Trekanten - Bibliotek og Kulturhus. The internal collaboration process became relevant in working together across the semester in one big production.

The goal for the semester was to create a performance based on the knowledge attained throughout the courses of the semester. To reach these goals we created the production of the performance called *Luscinia, Luscinia: En Nats Gale Fortællinger* [*Luscinia, Luscinia: One Nights Mad Stories*] (hereafter shortened to *Luscinia, Luscinia*).

The production started with H. C. Andersen's fairytale *The Nightingale* (1843) as a point of departure. The story is about a Chinese emperor, who through books discovers and falls in love with a nightingale, living in the forest. The court discovers the nightingale's presence and requests it to live by the emperor's side. Later on in the story, the emperor receives a mechanical bird from the Japanese emperor, as the name of the nightingale reaches beyond the Chinese emperor's land. The mechanical nightingale repeatedly sings the same melody, while the singing of real nightingale has its own manner. The court becomes more attentive to the mechanical bird, making the real nightingale leave, causing ridicule and banishing of the bird. The mechanical bird eventually wears out and may only be wound up once a year. Five years later, the emperor falls ill, leading to Death paying a visit. The emperor begs the mechanical bird to sing, but it is unable to do so. Unexpectedly, the real nightingale appears and sings a beautiful tune for the emperor, giving life back to the emperor and making Death leave. The emperor is grateful and promises the nightingale freedom to sing for him whenever it wants, without the public's knowledge.

This fairytale lay ground for the theatrical performance *Luscinia, Luscinia*. Its composition is separated into two different types of stories; one is a reading aloud of *The Nightingale* (referred to as *The Nightingale 2.0*) and the other is interpretations of *The Nightingale 2.0* (referred to as *The Interpreted Stories*). The plot switches between the two types of stories, illustrated in Figure 1. The plot of *The Nightingale 2.0* is divided into six parts with scenes from *The Interpreted Stories* in between, which is created with inspiration from the former *The Nightingale 2.0* scene. The individual scenes from *The Interpreted Stories* have their own independent plot. The Nightingale 2.0 scenes are continuously picking up from where it was parted by the Interpreted Stories.

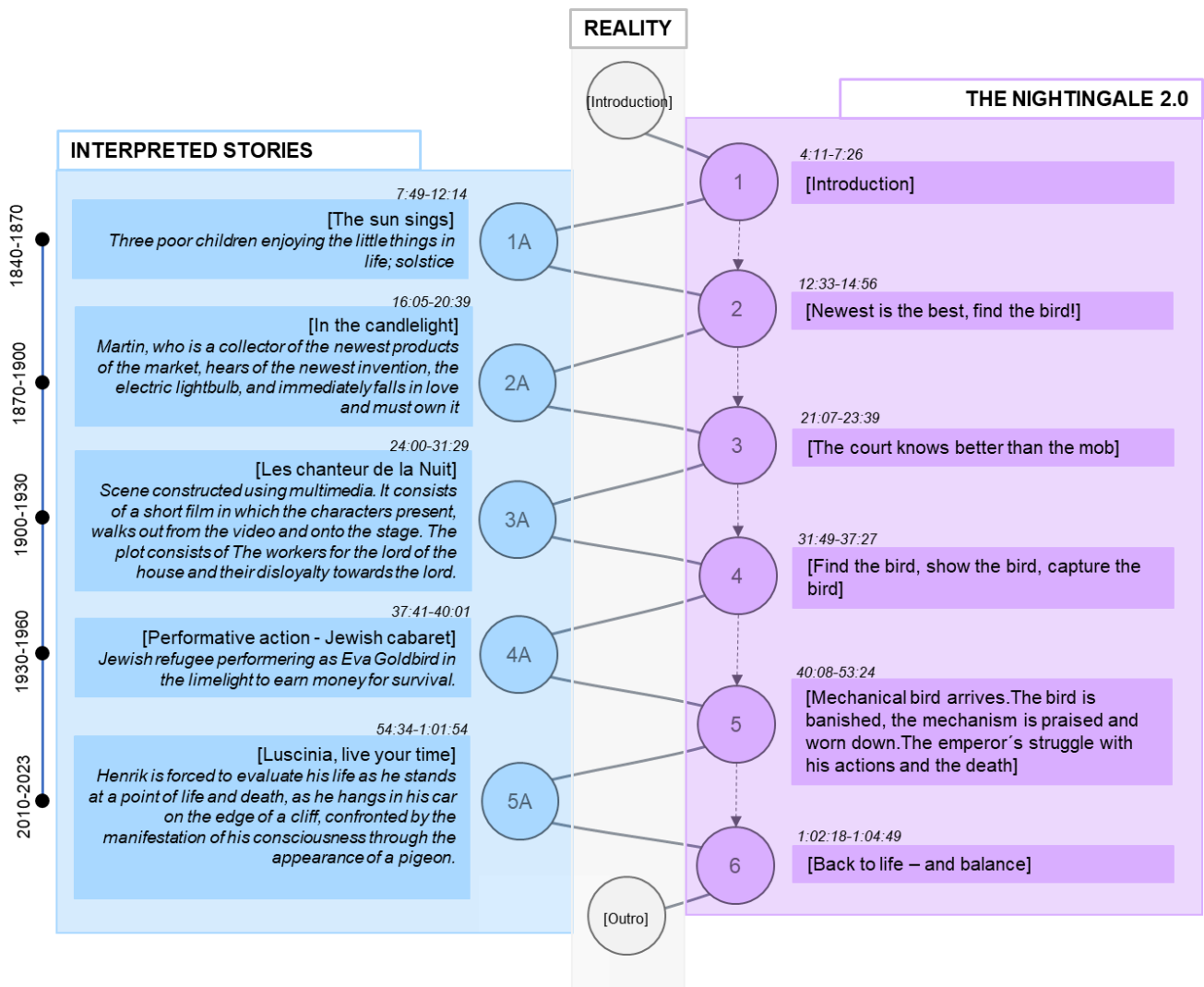


Figure 1: Visualisation of the storyline in the performance *Luscinia, Luscinia*. (See appendix 1 to view the full performance)

As one of the focuses in Luscinia, Luscinia was on new media, it became relevant to investigate the postdramatic aspects, which led us to have a focus on the influence of media on the stage design and adaptation of *The Nightingale*. The utilisation of new media, for switching between the storylines, became pivotal for the narration of the performance. This led to following problem statement, which guides the research of this report:

How can the use of media influence the narration and stage design of a theatrical adaptation based on an interpretation of the fairytale *The Nightingale* by H.C. Andersen?

This report will present and elaborate on relevant theories and terms in relation to the production. Furthermore it will explain how the project was created and evolved during the devising process. The end of the report includes an analysis of the performance on the basis of the problem formulation, which will be evaluated.

2. Background

2.1 Dramatic and Postdramatic Theatre

Storytelling has been part of human culture since the very beginning. We use storytelling to learn to understand one another's motives and choices different from our own (Nussbaum, 2003, p. nn). Through time, with new inventions storytelling has changed and evolved into expanded formats. One of the earliest works on literary theory is the *Poetics*(330BCE) by Aristotle. It touches upon some of the most essential aspects to drama. One of the key aspects of Aristotle is the three sections to a story; beginning, middle and end((*The Poetics of Aristotle*, 330 C.E., p. 12) Here it is argued that a well structured plot must conform to these elements. Modern theoreticians and artists challenged this model, one of which is Hans-Thies Lehmann, who in *Postdramatic Theatre* argues for an interpretation of these principles in a more contemporary sense:

[...] the dimension of the time shared by the performers and the audience as a processuality that is on principle open and has structurally neither beginning, nor middle, nor end. Aristotle had demanded precisely these, however, as a basic rule for drama, so that a whole(‘holon’) could come about. (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 155)

The Aristotelian view of action turns towards the idea of having a well constructed plot. This includes that a plot should have a single, central theme throughout the play(*The Poetics of Aristotle*, 330 C.E., p. 32). Events and actions should always contribute to the main storyline. Lehmann speaks of how the Aristotelian thinking about plot no longer encompasses a lot of instances within contemporary theatre. He notes that plot has shifted to a more fragmented, nonlinear approach in postdramatic theatre:

The mode of perception is shifting: a simultaneous and multi-perspectival form of perceiving is replacing the linear-successive. A more superficial yet simultaneously more comprehensive perception is taking the place of the centred, deeper one whose primary model was the reading of literary texts. (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 16).

It should be noted that Lehmann does not stand in opposition to Aristotle's view but rather works towards expanding this view. In the introduction of *Postdramatic Theatre*, Lehmann's theory is described as being a response to Peter Szondi's seminal *Theory of Modern Drama*. Lehmann contends the work as he describes Szondi's understanding of twentieth-century theatre development as limiting (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 3). Lehmann argues that there is a “dissolution of the dramatic concept of theatre within drama”(Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 4). He thus works with the understanding of expanding the view of the Aristotelian drama and its contained form.

Lehmann and Aristotle's perspectives on dramatic theory lay the ground for development of the theatrical performance with a fairytale as point of departure. To gather ideas of how others have approached adaptations of written texts, we looked at plays and performances based on written

texts; short stories and novels. The next two sections will be about adaptations of well-known stories.

2.2 *Mio, min Mio* (2023)

An example of an adaptation of a written novel is *Mio, min Mio* (2023), which was performed at Aalborg Teater. This production is a rendition of Hilde Brinchmann version from 2018 ('Mio, min Mio', n.d.). In the beginning of the semester, the production team experienced Aalborg Theatre's production, in order to establish an inspirational foundation for the development of our performance.

Mio, min Mio was performed within a small, flexible stage resembling a black box stage. The performance alternates between two scene areas, where the spectators swap places with the actors. Seated on the floor close to the actors, an intimate experience was created. The spectators become entangled in the narrative and turn into experiencers as the actors invite the audience into their universe (play world). The transition following the protagonist from the real world into a fantastical realm was quite literal, as the theatre space is a central element of the scenography, where the walls of the rooms become pages of a book. This book has transformative and moveable attributes with opening sides and windows, emphasising a low-tech approach, which makes it possible to easily change the scene (see Figure 2).

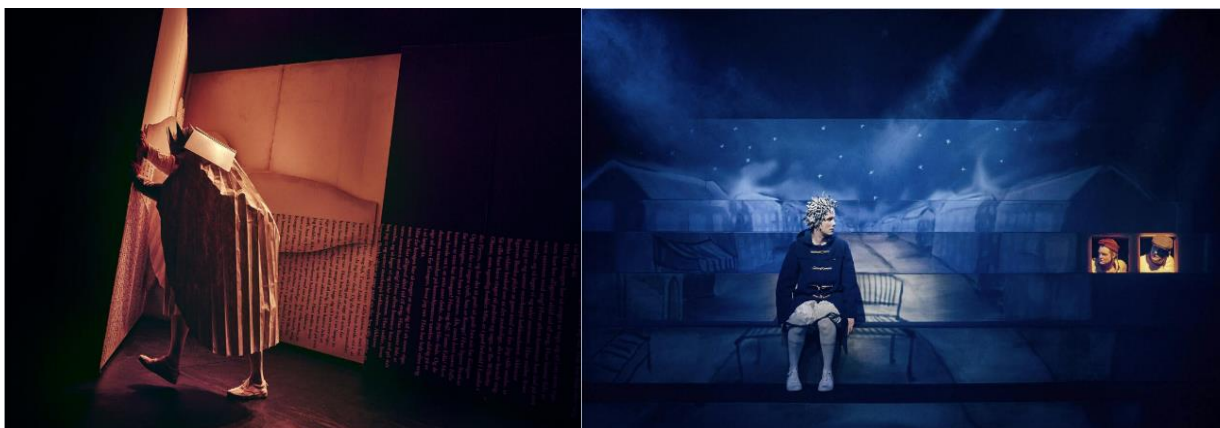


Figure 2: The transformative theatre space in a fantasy world (left) and the realm(right).
Source: <https://www.aalborgteater.dk/event/mio-min-mio/>

The minimalist stage design, using only few props with book aesthetics, prompts the audience's imagination to be challenged, as they must fill in spaces of the story world. This allows the actors to become a central element alongside technical aspects in the production. The strategic use of technical effects - such as light and sound - was instrumental in creating atmospheric nuances and underlining central actions in the performance.

2.3 *The Nightingale and Other Short Fables* (2021)

Another interpretation of a written text is *The Nightingale and Other Short Fables* directed by Canadian multimedia artist Robert Lepage. The Opera consists of multiple stories and storylines including H.C. Andersen's *The Nightingale*, Russian fables with musical influence from Asia, Europe and America.

The performance utilises aspects of puppetry, opera, and storytelling. The opera's first half consists of Russian short stories and the second half is *The Nightingale*, with a carefully planned scenography that transitions from Russia eastward. The change in setting is also seen in the puppets themselves as they are changing style and type as the setting changes.

The puppeteering involves not just moving the puppets, but also the character and voice of the puppet, creating an interesting dimension to the movement of body and performance. Lepage works on the performer's abilities and sensory aspects, reaching out to acrobats to fulfil the unusual style of opera. Lepage's opera allows spectators to see the process and technicalities of the production, allowing them to analyse and track the layers in both the visual and performative aspects of the performance. This approach follows parts of Lehmann's *Media in Postdramatic Theatre* (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 167). Within *The Nightingale* part of the opera, colour, puppetry, and music is utilised to create an atmosphere and underlining the central aspects of the narration (See figure 3).



Figure 3: Snapshot of *The Nightingale and Other Short Fables*; showing colour and puppetry.

Source: <https://www.opera-lyon.com/en/programme/2020-2021/en-famille/le-rossignol-et-autres-fables>

These two examples of performances based on literature, became inspirations for the development of *Luscinia*, *Luscinia*, through both conscious and unconscious decisions, which is further explained in Section 4.

3. Design Methods

The following sections will be the basis of the methods and theories relevant in the implementation and analysis of the performance. The chapter includes sections on devised theatre, narrative imagination, and media in theatre.

3.1 Devised Theatre

Devised theatre is a method used in theatre production, in which the process of creating a performance emerges from collective contributions, improvisation and exploration, where form and content is generated simultaneously, rather than following a traditional script. Often the places,

space, and people involved in the devising process, are being weaved into the immediate context of the performance. The devising process is typically an open-ended, labyrinthine journey, which may require an even stronger sense of structural organisation than demanded in a conventional performance. It can therefore become fundamental to create a 'memory-bank' in which tracking, cracking, and mapping the process from the beginning can be used to identify and articulate the evolving material. "The dramaturg documentation process presupposes that all ideas are potentially significant and could be used in new contexts" (Turner & Behrndt, 2016, p. 184). Revisiting initial starting points within the creative process offers valuable pauses, allowing the devisers to rethink and adjust with their original intentions. In order to maintain a collective understanding, it is vital to trace back to these origins jointly, so that everyone can contribute rather than solely hearing the director's vision.

Here it can become helpful to have a dramaturg to ensure that all within the production team are working according to the same artistic agenda. "(...) a key feature of the dramaturgs work in devising is to keep track of a fast-moving process, to maintain an overview, take stock and to help the company to construct or wright the performance" (Turner & Behrndt, 2016, p. 177). It can also become handy if the dramaturg can come with fresh eyes to make observations on structure and dynamics. For effective collaboration within the devising process, the dramaturg's role is to assist the director in articulating their "inner logic". For this reason, it would be beneficial if the dramaturg is not the playwright as well, as this dynamic could potentially complicate matters of authorship.

3.2 Nussbaum

Nussbaum writes about the world citizen, in Chapter 3 *The Narrative Imagination in Cultivating Humanity*. This refers to people needing to know much about the lives of others than their own to be equipped for citizenship (Nussbaum, 2003, p. nn). "The arts play a vital role, cultivating powers of imagination that are essential to citizenship" (Nussbaum, 2003, p. nn). Thus, people need to learn about others not just facts but also learn the ability to capacity for sympathetic imagination. One of

the ways people learn about this is through the arts. “Narrative art has the power to make us see the lives of the different (...)with more involvement and sympathetic understanding, with anger at our society's refusals of visibility” (Nussbaum, 2003, p. nn). We must train our imagination to be able to understand these elements, one area to promote this is storytelling.

“If literature is a representation of human possibilities, the works of literature we choose will inevitably respond to, and further develop, our sense of who we are and might be” (Nussbaum, 2003, p. nn). As the quote implies, can we as humans develop through literature, which is one of the grounding aspects using literature, for the development of other areas of art. Through the process of developing a theatre performance, we analysed the feelings of characters and the reasons for their actions, to be able to embody their feelings, which means “we must cultivate in ourselves a capacity for sympathetic imagination that will enable us to comprehend the motives and choices of people different from ourselves, seeing them not as forbiddingly alien and other, but as sharing many problems and possibilities with us” (Nussbaum, 2003, p. nn). Thus, not only are people learning, when being presented with a world, like being told a story, but also the person telling the story.

3.3 Media in theatre

Lehmann's *Postdramatic Theatre*, became a reference point for the discussions of contemporary theatre that has emerged since the 1970's (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 1). One of the key elements of this term is the degradation of the plot's importance, which is contradictory to dramatic theatre. Through this degradation other aspects became more important, one aspect is the exploration of the usage of media.

Since then, theorists have become increasingly interested in how media functions in theatre, one of them is David Saltz, he proposes a taxonomy *Sharing the Stage with Media* using multiple aspects regarding dramatic function, space and time to understand the relationship between the performer and media. Saltz defines media as encompassing: “audio, video, 3D animation, motion capture, holography, and robotics, among others” (Saltz, 2015, p. 95).

Saltz divides dramatic function into five categories: scene, prop, actor, costume, and mirror. Media can function as scene when it defines “the environment within which the performer is acting” (Saltz, 2015, p. 97). The media functions as props when the media becomes an object in which the performer can use. Media becomes an actor, when the media can be referred to as an autonomous agent by the actor. When the media is coextensive with the performer it functions as a costume, thus merging to define a character's identity and lastly when media functions as a mirror when it reflects the performer's actions (Saltz, 2015, pp. 99–103).

4. Implementation

4.1 Devising process

The performance emerged through a collective contribution, where everyone within the production team was assigned different roles. The process started thereby aligning expectations and talking about one's production role. An inevitable fact is the fairly small size of the class. With merely 10 people within the production team to devise the performance, multiple people had to be assigned with more than one role. We initially worked on more than was possible for us to execute, which during the week leading up to the performance forced us to scale down our ambitions. This resulted in cutting two of *The Interpreted Stories* out in order to finish the performance.

The performance was predetermined to be based on H.C. Andersens *The Nightingale*. For that reason, we started the process of exploring the story by brainstorming, trying to find a common understanding of the premise and themes of the fairytale. Here it was determined to make an adaptation of the story. The next phase was to find a direction for the performance, figuring out ideas and elements that could be incorporated. We accomplished this during another brainstorming session, where we separated the brainstorm into seven different sections; Puppets/Materials/Roles, Concepts/Plot, Interactive elements, Post-dramatic elements, Genre, Inspirational works and Others. After this session, we decided to focus on a framework with different timelines and multiple

interpreted stories, as we found it interesting how stories are told, transferred and interpreted throughout time. This made it possible to tell stories from various perspectives. From this basis, we divided our ideas into seven separate timelines with inspiration from our interpretation of *The Nightingale*(appendix), which was then translated into a manuscript. This laid a foundation for incorporating different layers of media, narration and scenography into our performance.

The manuscript became the centre of the development of the performance. This happened quite naturally, since we all knew the classic story in advance and therefore had different relationships with the story. This led to discussions around our different relationships and interpretations of the story's themes and messages. The 150-year-old story contains some universal themes that make it still relevant today. Over the years it has had different interpretations depending on age, society, class and personal values.

With the manuscript as centre, this meant that mise en scène had to be adapted into this context. In the week leading up to moving into Trekanten, the manuscript was constantly refined. Due to lack of time, we decided to prioritise the physical performative elements (acting and puppets), giving them first priority to use the stage at Trekanten as the technical elements should support and supplement the plot and atmosphere. Late in the process it was unclear whether many of the central props would be either physical or digital (projected). This together meant that the props and technical came into place last, as it had to be adapted to the manuscript.

Friday, leading up to the final week, a short consideration about returning to the point of departure was brought up but quickly turned down, due to the short amount of time until the deadline. This could have given us a shared understanding of our departure and what we sought to archive. Furthermore there was doubting communication about the responsibility for the various fields of work and contradictory information from the executive team, who had the overview of the evolving manuscript. This could have been avoided if we had been better at documenting the devising process. Since there was not a specific person directly assigned the role of dramaturg, this role became very fluid and everyone collectively took aspects of the role, as collaborators. One

instance in which the role of the dramaturg took an importance was during the rehearsals, where it became clear that the narrator had to stall time for the transitions between scenes, as well as being able solve problems that arose during the performance.

4.2 Props, Puppets and Costumes

Initially we intended to use few props, as the main focus should be on the puppets and the narration. The props consisted of both self-made and bought props; as some made more sense to buy(eg. electric candle lights), while other props were more logically to make ourselves (eg. the pigeon). Most props for *The Nightingale 2.0* were self made as we wanted a specific aesthetic inspired by book pages, but there were a few instances in *The Interpreted Stories*, where the book aesthetic was used as well. Examples of this were the flower bouquet, the books(the emperor is reading) and the apron the kitchen girl is wearing (see figure 4). To achieve this aesthetic, we used actual book pages, which were manipulated in various ways to achieve the desired looks.

The idea of using physical puppets came from *The Nightingale* itself. One of the central characters is a mechanical bird, hence ideas of what this could imply led us to questioning ideas of what mechanical puppets could be. In this sense the word mechanical doesn't refer to being



Figure 4: Props with the aesthetic of books

operated by a machine, where machines are artificial devices, but rather as being able to control the movement of action. Thus having a puppeteer operate the movements of the puppets.

For the puppets, we surveyed different styles of puppetry and decided on a few types including: bunraku, humanettes, finger puppets and stick puppets. The puppets were not made traditionally and in the authentic style of these cultural traditions, but rather made with the inspiration of the different types. The bunraku-inspired puppets were the Emperor and the cavalier (see Figure 5). One of the big differences between our puppet and the traditional bunraku is the difference in puppeteers, Bunraku traditionally has three, where ours had one. This was a decision made from constraints like the number of people we had available for the stage. The appearances of the puppets were made to fit into the narrative in the specific scene, which meant the puppets used in for instance Scene 1A [*The sun sings*], were made in the same style (see Figure 6), with the intent of creating cohesion both to the other scenic elements but also plot, in terms of the time periods that were relevant for the scene.

For the costumes of the puppets, a more elaborate costume was made for the specific character, custom made for the puppet. Design choices for the emperor were made with the basis of real historical emperors of China, to enable us to portray the position of the character. The research led us to a moodboard for the emperor (see figure 7).



Figure 5: The Emperor and cavalier from



Figure 6: Humanettes from Scene 1A [*The sun sings*]

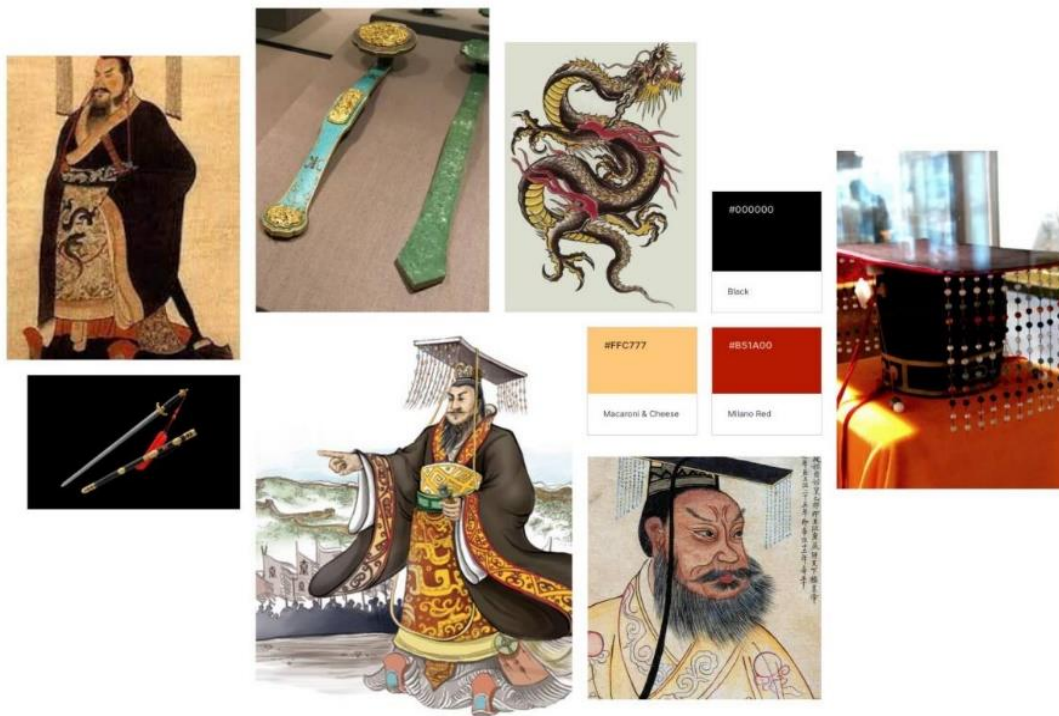


Figure 7: Moodboard of the emperor.

The costumes for the actors were from an early stage decided to be a black neutral outfit, with different additional clothing items and accessories, to portray different characters. This enabled the actors to make quick changes behind the stage, and be ready for the next scene, as new characters, some of the items included wigs and jackets.

4.3 The Stage

When developing the scenography, we were greatly inspired by the movement of the stage in *Mio, min Mio*(2023). At one point the actors move the walls of the stage revealing a new set. The idea of having a flexible stage with two types of storyline, led us to the idea of being able to move in two overall sections. For the narrator a third kind of section came into play, as that character was not a part of the two other sections but rather intervened one in a while.

Besides the sections of the stage, the characters move around the audience challenging the position of the stage. The audience was divided into two sections, allowing movement in-between them. This was utilised in some scenes, an example is Scene 2A[In the candlelight] where the

audience becomes guests of a wedding, when one of the characters enters the stage from behind, then walking down the aisle towards the groom. Figure 8 illustrates the movement of characters throughout the space of Aula in Trekanten. We categorise the overall movements; *The Nightingale 2.0*, *The Interpreted Stories* and the Narrator.

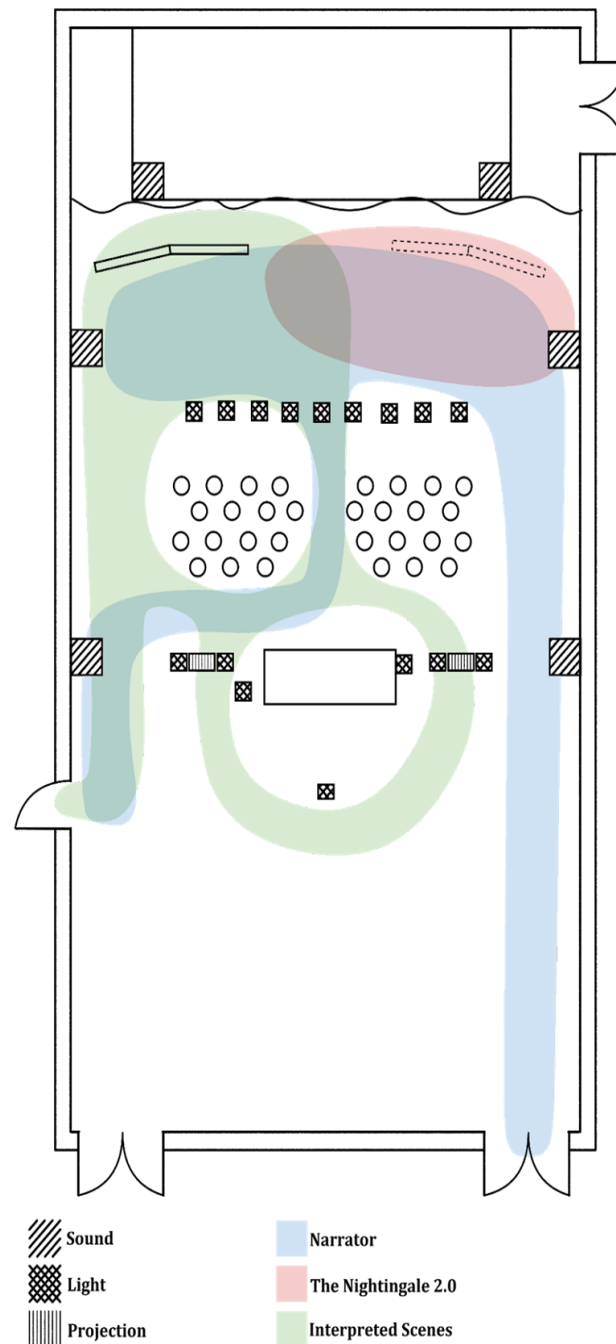


Figure 8: Movement of characters in the theatre space, and placement of technical equipment.

To move between the two sections of the play, we developed an over dimensional book, which could be moved to either section. By creating movement on the stage rather than a hard cut shift, the actors are given time to prepare themselves for the next scene while also allowing time for the audience to understand a change in scenes. These transitions become an essential element of the movement between *The Interpreted Stories* and *The Nightingale 2.0*.

4. 4 Scenography

The idea of using a book, came partly from many of us being familiar with the fairytale through a physical book version, while also being inspired by the scenography of *Mio, min Mio*. This led us to the idea of creating a book, as the primary scenographic element throughout the play. Having the book be on wheels, allowed the stage to be flexible and connected the two main sections of the plot.

We wanted the characters of the scenes to be within the parameters of the book, which meant we needed to make the book in a size that fit all characters and actors. This meant the size of the book ended up at a size of about 2.16m by 3.4m. Due to the movement of the book, some constructional aspects had to adhere to that. The book had to be large enough for it to fit the aforementioned requirements, while also being light enough for the actors to be able to move the book. It also had to have the ability to open and close, to emulate the physical aspects of a real book. We saw the opportunity of using a blackboard which already had the quality of being able to be closed and open and had wheels so it could be moved. This blackboard was not large enough, so we had to build a further construction on top of the blackboard to extend the size. As the book had to be covered to make "the pages" we needed to use building boards, with three qualities, lightweight, low cost and durable (due to transportation); achieved through DLH wood fibre building boards. The blackboard had a small section on either side that was taller than the actual board, which allowed the skeleton to be placed on top of each board on two small blocks of lath, which together with the sides of the book made the construction unable to detach from the blackboard when moved during the play.

The book also contained a hatch inspired from a similar principle from *Mio, min Mio*. The hatch could be used in multiple ways, we used it for example as a window and as a shelf, transforming the space for the plot's needs. The size was made to fit one human head, without leaving too much empty space around it. The construction of the book can be found in Figure 9.

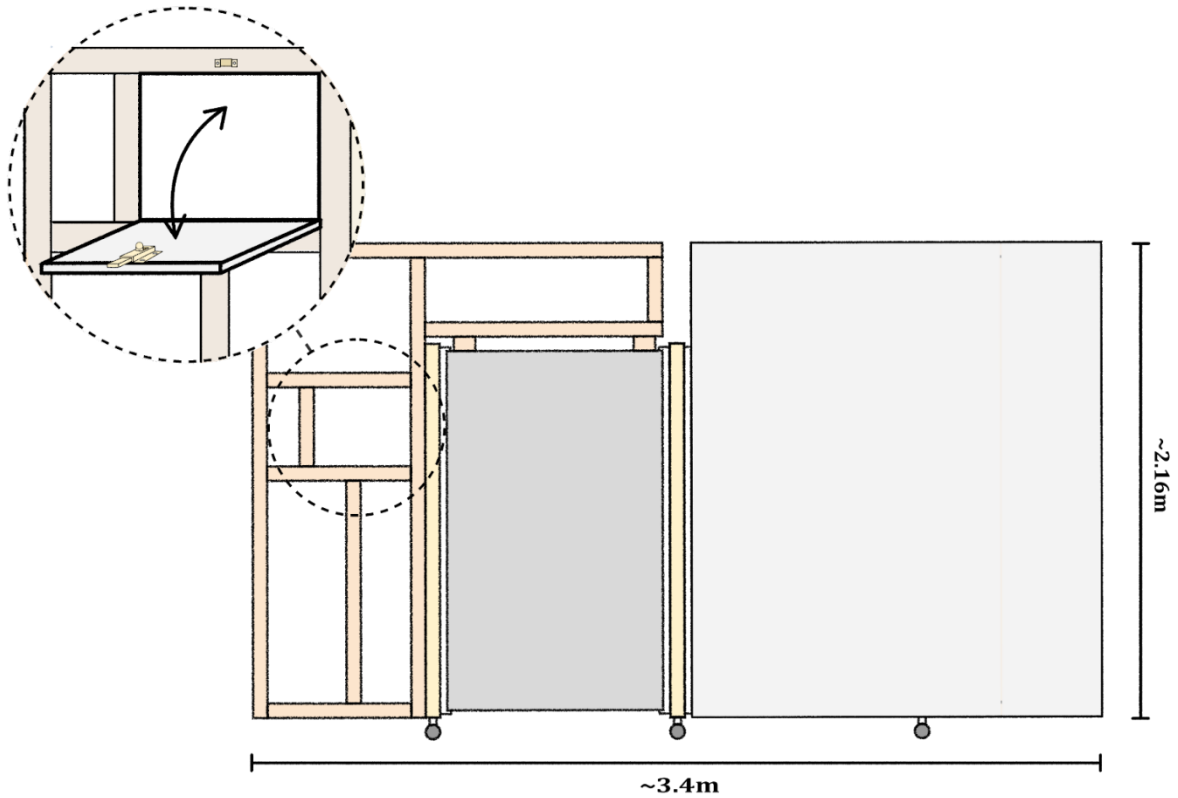


Figure 9: Construction of book.

4.5 Design of the production elements

The development of the technical elements was centred around the scenography and plot, by which it should become an interplay with the narrative, props, and acting. The technical elements revolve around stage lighting, projections and sound.

4.5.1 Light and projections

The development of the light design was aligned with the projections, so that the projection could be seen. In our performance the lights' primary function was to illuminate the stage elements. Thus in Scene 1A[The sun sings] the light takes over for the projections, as a sunrise appears. The design for projections was developed from the idea "if it's not refined, there's room for the eye and the soul to respond, the way you see a ruin." (Bell, 1997, p. 31). Therefore the illustrations should be the atmosphere and setting for the performance. In some of the scenes the projection should contain 'props' used within the plot. As described in Section 1. The plot is sectioned into two groups, whereby the design of the projections was developed in two various styles, dependent on whether the plot finds place within *The Nightingale 2.0* or *Interpreted Stories*.

The aesthetic for *The Nightingale 2.0* was made in relation to the original *The Nightingale* fairytale, whereby the text of the fairytale existed as a permanent background element, by which the illustrations were layered on top. These illustrations were inspired by the actions happening in the plot, eg. when the action takes place in the castle, a castle is illustrated (see figure 10). The overall style was consistent throughout *The Nightingale 2.0* in an old-time sketch style. The only scene with some variation is Scene 5 [The emperor's struggle with his actions and the death], where the colours of the illustration become inverted to match the mood of the plot(see figure 10).

The aesthetic for the projected illustrations of the Interpreted Stories aimed against various styles, due to the fact that they have five distinct plots finding place within five different ages. The illustration therefore varied in both the style, media type(still pictures, videos, photos, gifs) and

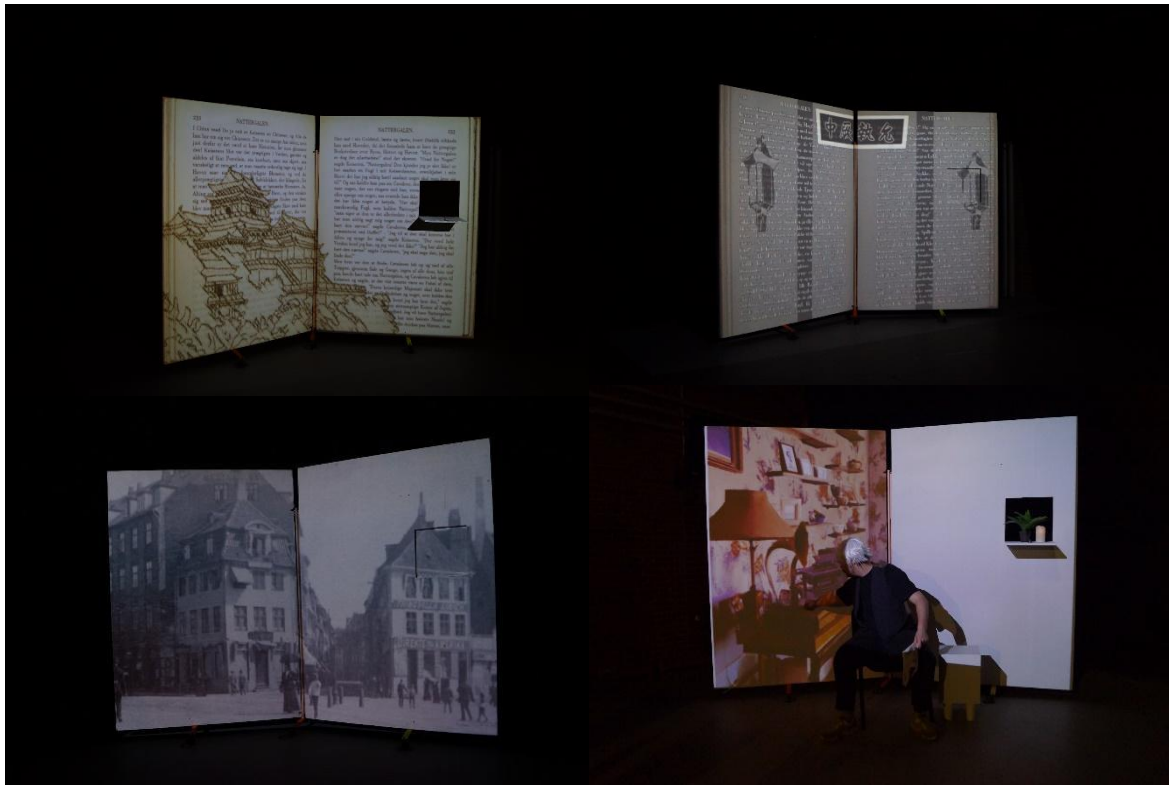


Figure 10: Illustrations projected on the physical book in both *The Nightingale 2.0*(top) and *The Interpreted Stories*(bottom).

development. This both imply photos created from AI-generators with edited content, a photo from achieve, video making with puppets and video from the internet.

4.5.2 Sound

The sound was functioning as an active performative element, playing back and forth with the actors. Therefore the sound designer and the actors needed to be highly attentive to each other during the performance, so that the actors could react to the sound and vice versa. Scene 2A [In the candlelight], where Martin telephones his friend, where the voice of the friend comes across as a muffled voice, which was controlled by the sound designer during the performance. Word cues from the actor indicated when the sound designer should play the next voice line as to which the actor then could reach. In this scene the sound plays with the actor and projection of a gramophone is 'turned' on by the actor, sending a cue for the soundtrack of a song. Thus, the world in the scene is created in a mixed reality world, blending the physical actor and props with digital projections and auditory inputs from speakers.

4.6 Production elements

The light consisted of two different kinds of lamps; two manually controlled follow spots, enhancing the narrator and pivotal events, and 14 ceiling stage lamps concentrated on creating the atmosphere for the scene. Furthermore, two ceiling projectors were mapped to fit the pages of the physical book on both sides of the scene. Both the stage lamps and projectors were controlled by a computer(PC2) using MadMapper. The setup of the projection, a PowerPoint slideshow, was operated on another computer (PC1), which was connected to PC2, allowing the PowerPoint to be controlled in MadMapper and mapped to the book through the projectors. A third computer screen was used to get an overview of the projected elements, as the screen contains a screen-split of PC1 and PC2 (Figure 11).

The sound was controlled by a synthesiser connected to PC2. This made it easy to adjust the sound level and switch between the soundtracks during the performance.



Figure 11: The setup of the technical in a performance context.

5. Analysis

In this analysis we will focus on the use of mixed media in our performance and discuss the relation between these medias.

The media is utilised within multiple ways in the performance and function as an integral part of the production. From an early stage the media were used as an inspirational foundation for both the design and aesthetic qualities. By using different media, the stage appearance and content was able to exemplify areas of the structure of the plot and mise en scène. The use of projections had a vital role in the flexible stage used in the performance. The projections not only allow the use of the scenery to create different worlds, but also functions as props in certain scenes. This was crucial for the execution of the performance, but the actual aspect of the written text also plays a vital part in the performance. Lehmann states one key aspect of performance: "Dramatic theatre is subordinated to the primacy of the text." (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 21), thus for the performance of dramatic theatre is working from the basis of the text, which is also the case for *Luscinia, Luscinia*. All actions and decisions happening in the performance stems from *The Nightingale* as a basis, even improvised and added lines in the performance are from the background of having a text basis.

5.1 The Structure of the Plot

In *Luscinia, Luscinia*, the structure of the plot deviates from the traditional Aristotelian view of one singular plot line (*The Poetics of Aristotle*, 330 C.E., p. 13), as the storyline of *The Nightingale 2.0* is continuously disrupted by the Interpreted Stories. While *The Nightingale 2.0* has a clear beginning, middle and end, The Interpreted Stories break the performance storyline into further parts. Lehmann is arguing that this notion of three aspects to a plot, is the frame for storytelling, as the logic behind theatrical reality, does not contradict the human reality, which does not follow a linear line (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 173). As the performance is built up around the plot of *The Nightingale*, the performance is rooted in the traditional plot-oriented drama, but through the

media takes on new perspectives and deviates from the traditional ways of adapting a story. Hence the structure of the performance is more in corresponds with that of post dramatic theatre, compared to dramatic theatre.

5.2 The Narrator as Driving Force

The narrator's ability to break the fourth wall, allows her to be omniscient. She is in control of what is happening on the stage, choosing when the performance moves along, while also interfering and commenting on the story, without the rest of the story being aware anything happens. The narrator is aware of the audience and the stage, can interact and sense the audience. Having moments in which the narrator pauses the story to say something to the audience, creates a double layer of reflection for the story. One of the main aspects of storytelling is having an audience/reader be able to learn about empathy; "a highly complex set of moral abilities, including the ability to imagine what it is like to be in that person's place" (Nussbaum, 2003, p. nn)

There is a reader of the story while there is also an audience of the performance story, both aware that there is a story, which enables both to be reflecting on the story. In one instance, the narrator wonders about the 'p' told within the original *The Nightingale*, thus she reflects about her experience as being a story-teller. Implying the narrator's reflective attitude, asking questions to the audiences, may bring points for the audience to reflect on themselves. In another instance, the narrator comments on the plot, in regards to an action happening to a character. Here the narrator interjects with a "oof yikes" (see appendix 2, p.14), which indicates the narrator's empathetic thoughts towards the characters.

By having the narrator speak directly to the audience, the narrator can guide them into different experiences. For most of the time the audience are experiencing the performance in a dramatic theatre style, where the audience are observers watching a story unfold before their eyes. In dramatic theatre "the stage frame functions like a mirror that ideally allows a homogeneous world of the viewers to recognize itself in the equally coherent world of the drama." (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 150).

Through *Luscinia*, *Luscinia* this notion of stage is challenged. The audience is at times brought into the story, almost like characters. In Scene 2A [In the candlelight], a wedding takes place where the narrator requests the audience to stand up for the bride. Thus, the dramatic space of the performance changes shape while also changing the role of the audience. In this instance the actors and audience have a level of commonality between them (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 152). Thus, the narrator plays a vital role in relation to the audience, the characters and the story itself, and she functions as the driving force for the plot.

5.3 Puppets and Imagination

When incorporating puppets into the performance, it facilitates the possibility to work within the realm of realism. By incorporating puppets into the performance, multiple aspects are brought into play, one aspect is the realm of realism. There was a rediscovery of objects in performance in the west, which meant “that historical phenomenon, by tapping into the non-realistic, anti-logical, and even fetish roots of puppets, masks and other performed materials, was an antitheatrical response to the development of European tenets of positivism, rationality, and realism” (Bell, 1997, p. 29). Thus, the puppets play a part in reducing realism in performance. It allows a clear distinction between real and fictional, which is one of the key elements of *Luscinia*, *Luscinia*, as the fictional stories come with real emotions and actions allowing the audience to experience the fictional life and implement it into their own world.

5.4 Interplay between Virtual and Live Actors through Media

Being able to play with the use of media in the performance led to different perspectives of how to tell a story. One example is the experimentation of using both live actors, and finger puppets through a video installation, in Scene 3A [Les chanter de la Nuit]. The media transcends and becomes an important aspect of telling the story of this scene. Here the theatre performance meets with the media art in the form of the video installations (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 168). This scene deviates from the rest of the performance in one aspect in particular, the narration. Throughout the performance, there is a descriptive narration of the actions in the scenes, while Scene 3A gives very

little information to the audience. They are therefore pushed into looking at the scene as a whole and piece together the plot for themselves.

The use of puppets in this scene, revolves around the relation between the live actors and the virtual actors. Based on Saltz's idea of *Media as actor*, the character on screen becomes an actor in their own right (Saltz, 2015, p. 100). The virtual characters become responsive actors to the live actors. While this is created through the illusion of responsiveness in the media, as the video is a prerecorded sequence where the actor adapts their actions according to the video characters. An interesting aspect of the scene is the play of who is the characters, as the live actors and the virtual actors are playing the same characters. To visualise this aspect the characters are made to have specific identifies, such as a rose in the hair, to connect the two actors to the same character. Interesting elements of this scene also includes space and time. The live actors would be categorised as here, by the taxonomy Saltz proposes, while the virtual actor is in a virtual space. The live actors are standing on stage in the theatre, while the virtual actors are transported into a set in a different world. The scene works with a performer-media interaction in the performance (Saltz, 2015, p. 105), specifically looking at the relationship between the video- and live acting, as each of the shifts between the video and live acting creates an illusion of the continuous storyline. This continuation is created as the scenes before determines what happens next, thus the virtual characters actions reflect the actions of the live actors and vice versa. Having two different actors play the same character, through different media, creates a shift in the scenery, thereby creating two scenic worlds in the same storyline.

5.5 Summing up

The performance is made from a base in dramatic theatre, like the plot-oriented structure, while implementing various elements of post dramatic theatre to create a novel approach to an adaptation of a written story. Through this exploration the possibilities with different media, untraditional usage of the elements gave a new spark and perspective on a well-known, fairytale. The performance is working with traditions of theatre, viewing the traditions with an open-mind and

exploring how these elements can develop into something different. The context, in which the performance has been made, greatly influenced the production process as well as the final performance. As the contemporary theatre, where there is an increased focus on deconstruction of theatre (Lehmann & Jürs-Munby, 2006, p. 1).

6. Collaboration

This section consists of an individual self-evaluation on our contribution to the production team and reflection upon the collaboration with Trekanten.

6.1 Emilie

My experience within the devising process of our theatrical performance was overall positive. Within the production team, I was designated the role of projection designer. My role came into play relatively late, as the manuscript was the focal point of the performance and changes within the manuscript were continually made towards the end. Furthermore, there was a lack of documentation of the process, and confusion within the communication from the executive team passed on to the designers, which at one point made it difficult to understand the overall artistic vision. This made me advocate for going back to the starting point, to gather a collective understanding of the concept. Unfortunately, I did not feel like the suggestion was taken well, due to time pressure. However, our communication about our feelings and wellbeing were proper good, which created a comfortable and open space to talk about the difficulties within the production of the performance.

Two weeks before the performance I started developing the design for the projections together with the scenographer, artist director and playwright. We worked towards deciding which elements and props should be either digitally illustrated or physically manufactured, so that the narrative within the plot made sense, without giving too much away, so there still was room for the audience's imagination to interpret the performance. Due to the short amount of time, the illustrations of *The Interpreted Stories* were delegated between the people with extra time. Together

with the light and sound designer, we collaborated towards making the technical elements work in practice. When arriving at Trekanten, my task was to set up the technical gear, then afterward make the projections fit the physical book. During the performance I manage the displaying of the projections. After the last performance, I took the responsibility for photo documenting the production.

6.2 Luna

In the production I contributed in many aspects more than I first had anticipated. At the beginning I was given the role of scenographer/set designer. This meant I took the lead of creating the physical environment for the performance, this was done in collaboration with, in particular, the projection designer and the puppetmaster, to ensure a cohesiveness of the elements on stage.

During the development, assistance for the artistic director was needed, and as I had a general view of the production, because of my assigned role, I began to assist. This meant my contribution to the play became much larger. I assisted at first by helping create a blueprint to understand the manuscript in relation to its adaptation for the stage. This was then further worked on by the art director while I continued my role as set designer.

During the stay at Trekanten, I helped further in devising the play, having conversations with the different members in regard to the feasibility of aspects of the play. Here I took part in suggesting the removal of elements of the performance, to ensure a coherent performance in the end. Right before the performance I ended up with the task of helping backstage. which meant I ended up working with the actors, handling the props and helping the actors in and out of outfits for the different scenes. While having this many aspects to work in was quite demanding, I ended up with the feeling that I contributed largely in the production of what ended up being a good performance.

7. Future work

One of the points we would like to have a look at is in terms of the devising process, being able to go back and revisit some of the earlier ideas, and seeing what may come from that. As Turner

and Behrndt writes: "Remembering and returning to things can provide a key to understanding the work at difficult moments." (Turner & Behrndt, 2016, p. 181). Due to time, priorities had to be made in order to focus on the most necessary aspects of the performance. This meant ideas of technological implementation in the performance had to be de-prioritised, as they were not directly necessary to convey the story. But if the possibility arose of being able to develop more aspects of the performance, these technological implementations are some of the possible areas we would like to work with. As we were working on the report one aspect of the devising process always seemed to come back to us, how did we actually get to the performance. Therefore we would like to further look back on the devising process, it would be interesting to take a look at how the performance actually took its shape, and understand what led to each process. How decisions were made and what led to it.

For more concrete work with the actual performance would be developing some of the ideas we had to put aside along the process, mainly due to time. Interactive elements from mixed reality would be one of the general areas we would look further into. It could be working with developments of the media of puppets, having some puppets be virtual, while also being able to control them in real time. One of the ideas of Scene 5A [Luscinia, live your time], was to have a virtual manifestation Luscinia, having the voice be triggered by movement of an actor or audience member, perhaps trickering the lines.

8. Conclusion

In seeking answers to the problem statement, defined in Section 1, we analysed the use of media in relation to the narration and stage design for the performance of *Luscinia*, *Lucinia*. Through the lens of Lehmann's *Postdramatic Theatre* a reflection, upon the process of developing a performance in the contemporary time, reveals doors opening in exploring usages of media. Using media enables story worlds to unfold in both physical and virtual worlds, which in this performance

was evident. Two worlds of one storyline are revealed as the media becomes actors in the performance in coexistence with live actors, through a video installation.

Having media and a flexible stage be one of the core elements of the performance allows a plot to be told through multiple storylines. As the transitions between the storylines can be guided through the two elements. Using the narrator as a guide through the plot, enables the performance to have self-reflection, which is an elementary aspect of storytelling. To understand the use of media for the storytelling, we looked at Nussbaum's *The Narrative Imagination* to understand the importance of stories and storytelling, from which we saw how the performance usage of a narrator creates room for reflecting on the story. The narrator speaks directly to the audience, bringing them into the thoughts and feelings of the characters in the storyline.

We believe through the devising process and the research of this report, that an understanding of our learning processes and theories of the narration, performance design and more, enabled us to reach this semester's goal on creating a performance based on the knowledge we have gotten throughout the semester.

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Appendix

Appendix 1: Full length video of performance, attached in Digital Eksamen.

Appendix 2: Manuscript, attached in Digital Eksamen.